

TOURISM

Choppy Waters

The derogatory remarks of now-suspended Maldivian ministers have not only led to calls for a boycott of the island nation but also a surge in demand for domestic destinations like Lakshadweep

22 |

BY PRERNA LIDHOO & SURABHI

► **SOON AFTER MALDIVIAN** politician Zahid Rameez triggered a controversy by mocking the beaches of Lakshadweep on January 5—in the wake of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit there—all hell broke loose on the internet. The hashtag #BoycottMaldives was trending on social media in India.

This incident has, predictably, triggered a diplomatic row, given Maldivian President Mohamed Muizzu's pro-China stance. But it also appears to have sparked a big shift in Indians' travel plans to the island nation and a move towards domestic destinations, with Lakshadweep topping the charts.

Travel and tourism companies say they are seeing a huge spike in searches for Lakshadweep on their online portals, while the Maldives is already seeing cancellations of trips.

SIGNS OF STRAIN MAY PERSIST BECAUSE MALDIVIAN PRESIDENT MUIZZU'S FIRST FOREIGN VISIT WAS TO CHINA

Per the Indian Association of Tour Operators (IATO), the impact of the boycott call would become apparent in 20–25 days. “Many Indians on social media have claimed that they have cancelled their planned holidays to the island nation,” says IATO President Rajiv Mehra. He adds that there are no new inquiries for the Maldives. “Those who have made payments will not cancel them. We are expecting that people will not book trips to the Maldives.”

Thomas Cook (India) Limited said its search data for Lakshadweep indicates a significant jump of over

950 per cent compared with December, followed by destinations like the Andamans, Goa, Kerala's Kovalam, and Daman and Diu—which is a clear catalyst for domestic tourism, says Rajeev Kale, President & Country Head—Holidays, MICE, Visa, Thomas Cook (India) Limited. “With the Prime Minister's recent visit to Lakshadweep and encouragement to Indians to explore islands within the country, we have witnessed an uptick in searches for both domestic island and beach destinations,” he says.

EaseMyTrip was one of the first to jump on the bandwagon with its viral



SURFING THE WAVES Travel companies have seen a huge surge in demand for Indian destinations after the incident